HIGH PATHOGENICITY AVIAN INFLUENZA (HPAI)

Situation Report 86

Period covered:

August 2026

This report provides an update on the high pathogenicity avian influenza (HPAI) situation, according to the information submitted to the World Organisation for Animal Health.

Key messages and Recommendations

The new HPAI season, which started in October 2025, continued in August 2026 with **3** outbreaks being reported in poultry and **42** outbreaks in non-poultry species including wild birds and in mammals in Africa, Asia, Oceania, Americas and Europe for the reporting month. About **74,903** poultry birds died or were culled during the month.

The current epidemic wave reached the highest peak of poultry outbreaks in November 2025. Since then, the number of poultry outbreaks has shown a decreasing trend in the Northern hemisphere, which is consistent with the known seasonality of HPAI in poultry. On the other hand, as of July 2026, the number of HPAI detections in wild birds during the current season was significantly higher than in the two previous full epidemic seasons, particularly in Europe, with 7,444 outbreaks reported.

In July 2026, HPAI new outbreaks in mammals were reported in a cat and in a mustalid in the United States of America. Meanwhile, researchers present on site did not report suspected cases of HPAI in the sub-Antarctic islands and Antarctica proper (https://scar.org/library-data/avian-flu). WOAH continues to pay close attention to the situation of HPAI in all species across the world.

Given the spread of HPAI across the globe, continued surveillance in wild and domestic animal species is warranted. As this pathogen is impacting wildlife, livestock, and public health, a One Health approach to management would be beneficial. WOAH recommends that Members maintain their surveillance efforts, implement biosecurity and preventive measures at farm level, and continue timely reporting of avian influenza outbreaks in both poultry and non-poultry species. It is important to remember that early detection is our most effective form of prevention. Transparency and solidarity are key to strengthening global preparedness, which requires sustained investment and collaboration across sectors.

Considering the situation in mammals, WOAH also recommends:

- including avian influenza as a differential diagnosis in mammals with high risk of exposure to the viruses;
- reporting to WOAH outbreaks of avian influenza in all animal species including unusual hosts;
- sharing genetic sequences of avian influenza viruses and associated metadata in publicly available databases;
- protecting humans in close contact with sick livestock and their products, while avoiding implementing unjustified trade restrictions.

High quality of information is key to support prevention and rapid response to HPAI.

Objective of the report & limitations

Based on Chapter 1.3 of the *Terrestrial Animal Health Code (2024)*, three categories of avian influenza are listed by WOAH: 1) infection with high pathogenicity avian influenza viruses (HPAI) (in poultry, as defined in the disease-specific chapter), 2) infection of birds other than poultry, including wild birds, with HPAI, and 3) infection of domestic and captive wild birds with low pathogenicity avian influenza (LPAI) viruses having proven natural transmission to humans, associated with severe consequences. Based on Chapter 3.3.4 of the *Terrestrial Animal Health Manual (2025)*, infection of bovines (*Bos taurus*) with influenza A viruses of high pathogenicity in poultry is defined as an emerging disease by WOAH.

This report provides an update of the situation as of 31 August 2026 according to the information submitted to WOAH through the World Animal Health Information System (WAHIS) and aims to contribute to awareness of the global situation. Although all the information used in this report is already publicly accessible via the WOAH website, the report aims to intelligently combine these various sources of information to present WOAH Members with the most accurate information possible, while recognising the limitations of the data available on a global scale.

This month's report covers the HPAI situation only, as WOAH has not been informed of any exceptional event of infection of domestic and captive wild birds with LPAI viruses having proven natural transmission to humans, associated with severe consequences.

Contextual information

Since its identification in China (People's Rep. of) in 1996, there have been multiple waves of intercontinental transmission of the H5Nx Gs/GD lineage virus. HPAI has led to the death and mass slaughter of over 633 million poultry worldwide between 2005 and 2024, with an unprecedented peak of 146 million in 2022. During the peak in 2022, 84 countries and territories in the world were affected with HPAI, a number comparable to the 82 affected in 2024. In addition, up to now, humans have been occasionally infected with several subtypes of avian influenza (mainly H5N1, H7N9, H5N6, H9N2 with more than 2500 cases since 2003)[1][2].

[1] https://www.who.int/teams/global-influenza-programme/avian-influenza/monthly-risk-assessment-summary
[2] Cumulative number of confirmed human cases for avian influenza A(H5N1) reported to WHO, 2003-2023, 21 December 2023

As described in the Animal Health Situation Worldwide and The State of the World's Animal Health reports presented by WOAH during its 93rd General Session of the World Assembly of Delegates in May 2026, HPAI has been a global concern, particularly since October 2020, due to an unprecedented situation marked by:

- its global spread and the increase in the number of countries and territories affected worldwide, including an unprecedented spread to Antarctica in 2024;
- the increase in the number of outbreaks and losses in poultry, with a peak during the seasonal wave October 2021-September 2022;
- the increased impact on wildlife and biodiversity;
- the increase in the number of cases detected in domestic and wild mammals.

Seasonality of HPAI outbreaks in poultry

Figure 1 focuses on poultry outbreaks and shows the seasonality of HPAI separately for the northern and southern hemispheres. It covers the seasonal wave which started in October 2025 (October 2025 to September 2026), as well as the two previous waves for comparison.

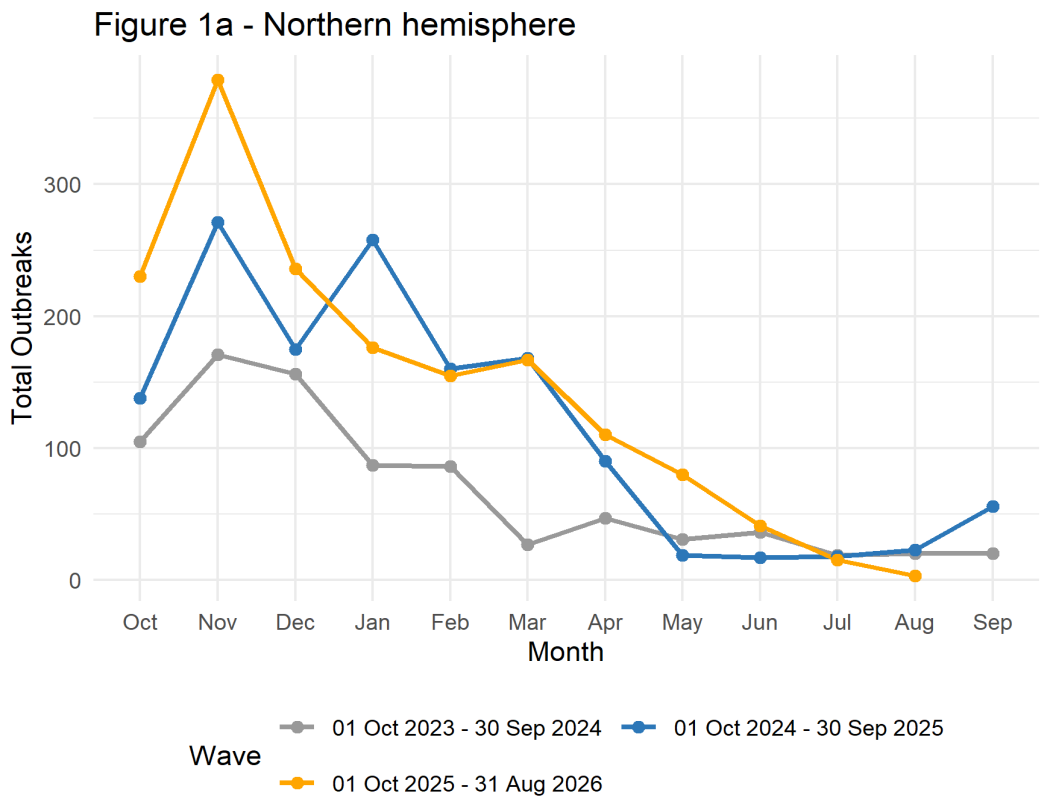
HPAI key figures for the current seasonal wave and the two previous waves

Table 1. HPAI key figures for the current seasonal wave and the two previous waves

	01 Oct 2023 - 30 Sep 2024	01 Oct 2024 - 30 Sep 2025	01 Oct 2025 - 31 Aug 2026
Countries and territories reporting HPAI in poultry	39	51	46
No. of HPAI outbreaks in poultry	851	1,431	1,619
Countries and territories reporting HPAI in wild birds	55	55	59
No. of HPAI outbreaks in wild birds	1,076	1,926	7,444

*Please note that regarding the 'Countries and territories reporting HPAI in poultry' in the current seasonal wave, two countries reported stable situations through six monthly reports and are not covered in the "recent updates" section below.

Regarding the 'Countries and territories reporting HPAI in wild birds' in the current seasonal wave, one out of 59 countries/territories reported stable situation through six monthly reports and are not covered in the "recent updates" section below.



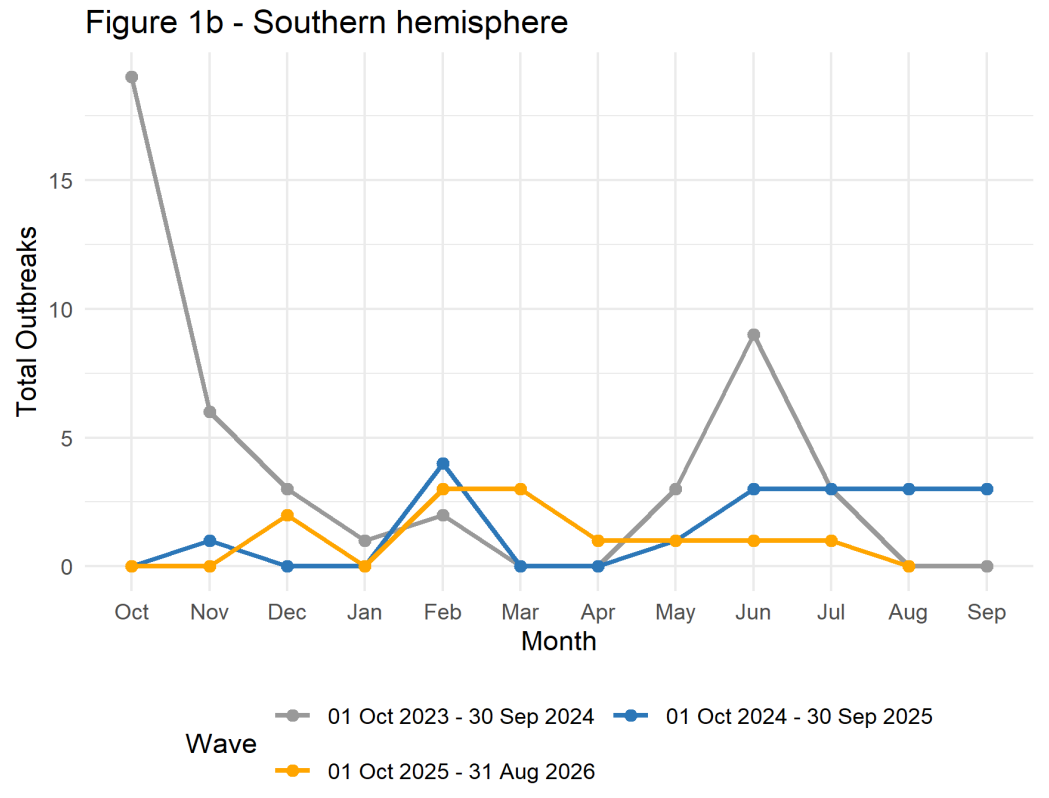


Figure 1. HPAI outbreaks of August 2026 in poultry reported to WOAH by seasonal waves. The current wave started in October 2025 (October 2025 to September 2026); the previous waves are included for comparison. Data is presented by month and by hemisphere. *For the southern hemisphere (Figure 1b), it is important to highlight that the seasonality analysis does not consider Indonesia, which has declared a sufficiently stable situation to WOAH to provide data aggregated by semester (and not by month). This is an important limitation, as the country reported an average of 17 outbreaks per six-month period between the second half of 2022 and the second half of 2023, which is significant on a hemispheric scale.

HPAI map for the current seasonal wave (Oct 2025-Sep 2026, as of August 2026)

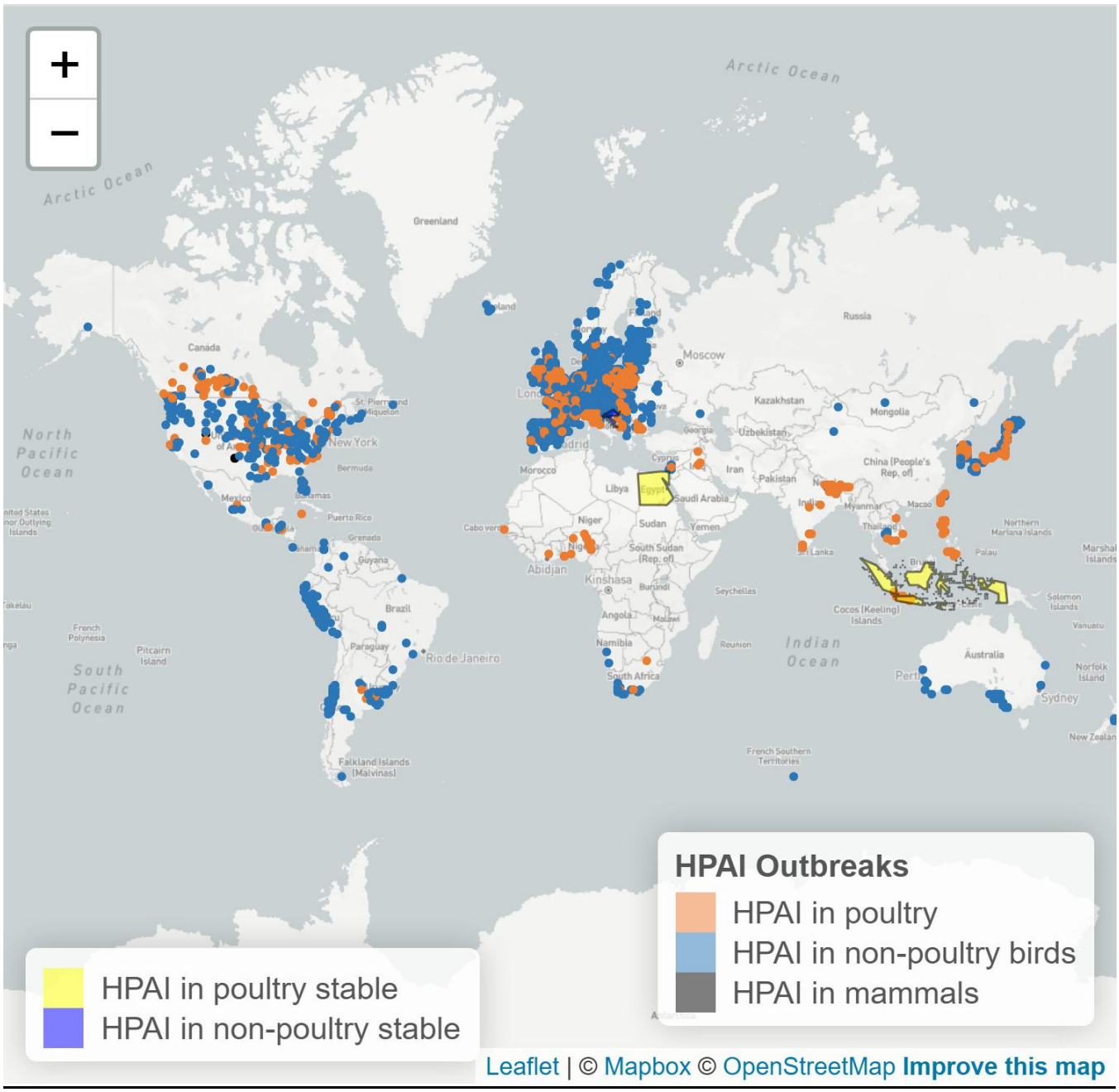


Figure 2. HPAI map for the current seasonal wave (October 2025-September 2026, as of August 2026). Please note that highlighted countries/territories in the map declared HPAI in poultry/non-poultry sufficiently stable for information to be reported on six-monthly basis without geocoordinates. The country in the purple category is Croatia (hidden by the outbreak dots that cover it).

Recent Updates (August 2026)

To describe the current disease situation of HPAI in poultry and in non-poultry birds, this section covers: (a) a list of new events[3] which started in August 2026 (reported through immediate notifications); (b) information on events that started before August 2026 but were still ongoing during that period; (c) the geographic distribution of new outbreaks[4] that started in August 2026, together with figures on numbers of outbreaks, cases, losses and animals vaccinated in response to outbreaks. The different subtypes of HPAI circulating during August 2026 are also listed below. This information is based on the immediate notifications and follow-up reports received by WOAH through the World Animal Health Information System (WAHIS).

HPAI in poultry

New events by world region (reported through immediate notifications)

Region	Sub/genotype	Clade	Country/territory	Subnational area	Event_Start_Date
Asia and the Pacific	H5N1		Chinese Taipei	Taipei	8 August 2026

On-going events for which there were new reported outbreaks, by world region (reported through follow-up reports):

Region	Sub/genotype	Clade	Country/territory
Americas	H5N1		United States of America
Europe	H5N1		Sweden

New outbreaks

During the period covered by this report, 3 new outbreaks in poultry were notified by 3 countries and territories (Chinese Taipei, Sweden, United States of America). Details are presented in Figures 3 and 4.

[3] As defined in Article 1.1.2. of the WOAH Terrestrial Animal Health Code, an "event" means a single outbreak or a group of epidemiologically related outbreaks of a given listed disease or emerging disease that is the subject of a notification. An event is specific to a pathogenic agent and strain, when appropriate, and includes all related outbreaks reported from the time of the initial notification through to the final report. Reports of an event include susceptible species, the number and geographical distribution of affected animals and epidemiological units.

[4] As defined in the glossary of the WOAH Terrestrial Animal Health Code, an "outbreak" means the occurrence of one or more cases in an epidemiological unit.

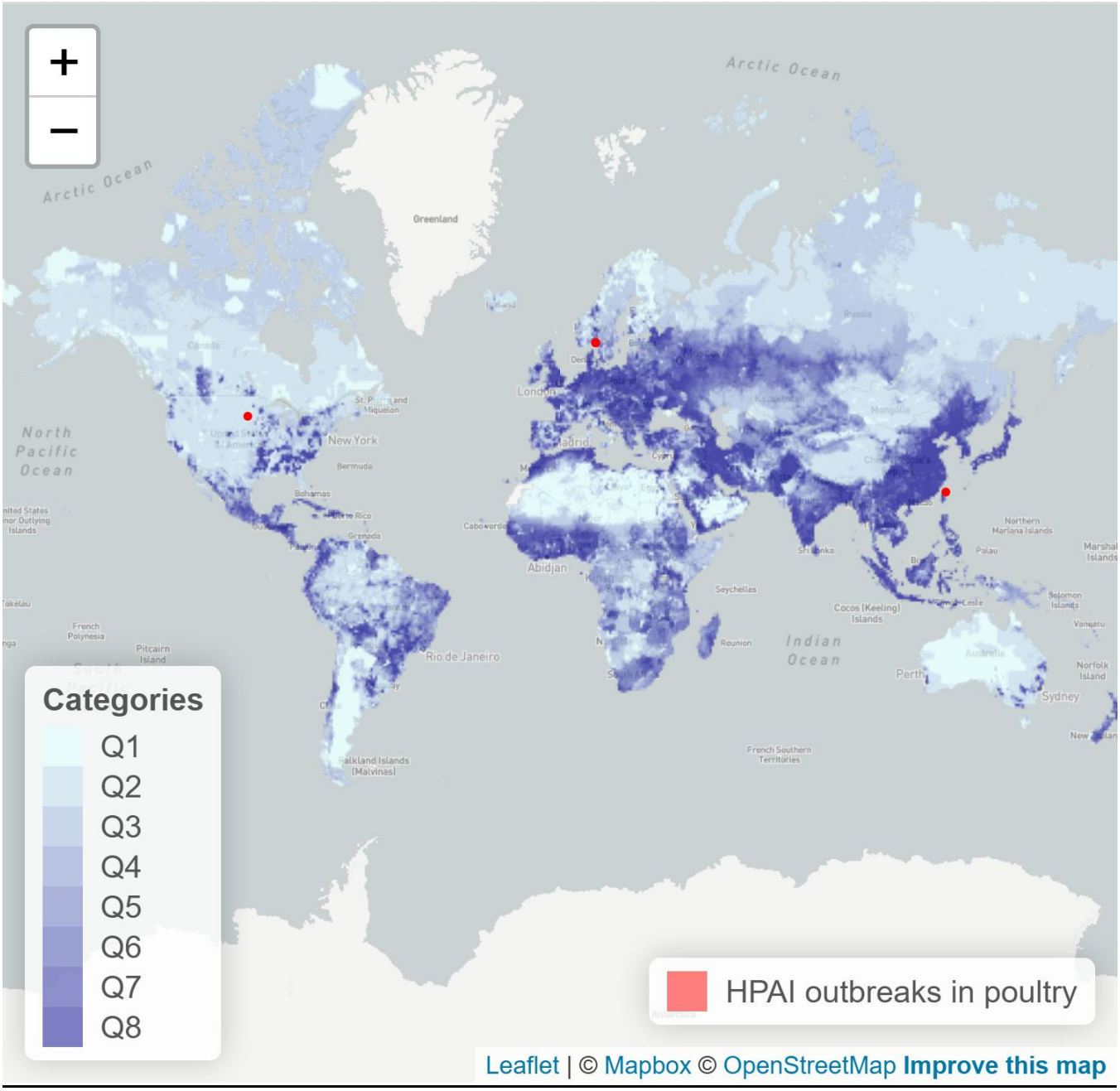


Figure 3. Distribution of HPAI new outbreaks in poultry. The outbreaks are presented on top of the chicken density layer[5] produced by the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations (FAO) - GLW 4: Gridded Livestock Density (Global - 2020 - 10 km)

[5] Layers for the distribution of other poultry species (such as ducks, turkeys, geese, etc.) are not currently available under FAO GLW 4: Gridded Livestock Density (Global - 2020 - 10 km).

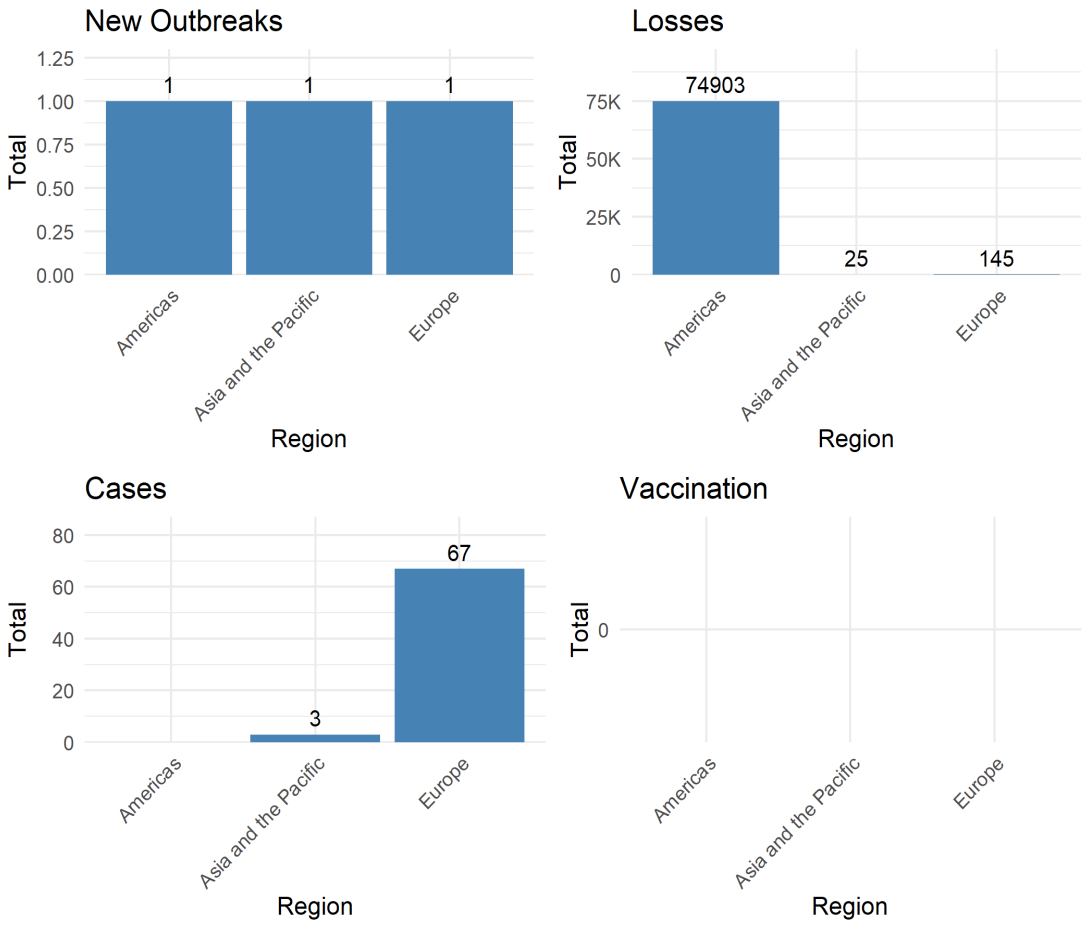


Figure 4. Number of new outbreaks, associated cases and losses (losses include animals dead and killed and disposed of within outbreaks – they do not include culling around outbreaks). It should also be noted that some countries or territories are unable to provide a precise number of cases and leave this field blank in the report.

HPAI in non-poultry

New events by world region (reported through immediate notifications)

Non-poultry birds

Region	Sub/genotype	Clade	Country/territory	Subnational area	Event_Start_Date

On-going events for which there were new reported outbreaks, by world region (reported through follow-up reports):

Non-poultry birds

Region	Sub/genotype	Clade	Country/territory
Americas	H5N1		Brazil
Asia and the Pacific	H5N1		Australia , New Zealand
Europe	H5N1		Netherlands , Portugal , Denmark , United Kingdom , Norway

Mammals

Region	Sub/genotype	Species	Clade	Country/territory
Americas	H5N1	Cats		United States of America
Americas	H5N1	Mustelidae		United States of America

New outbreaks

Antarctica

No HPAI confirmed and suspected cases were reported in the subantarctic islands and in Antarctica proper during June 2026. Details coming from the Scientific Committee on Antarctic Research (SCAR) are available here: https://scar.org/library-data/avian-flu. The Updated Biological Risk Assessment and Recommendations for Highly Pathogenic Avian Influenza in Antarctica published on behalf of the SCAR Antarctic Wildlife Health Network on 18 December 2024 presents a summary of the situation as well as recommendations.

During the period covered by this report, 42 new outbreaks in non-poultry were notified by 8 countries and territories (Australia, Brazil, Denmark, Netherlands, New Zealand, Norway, Portugal, United Kingdom)[6]. Details are presented in Figures 5 and 6.

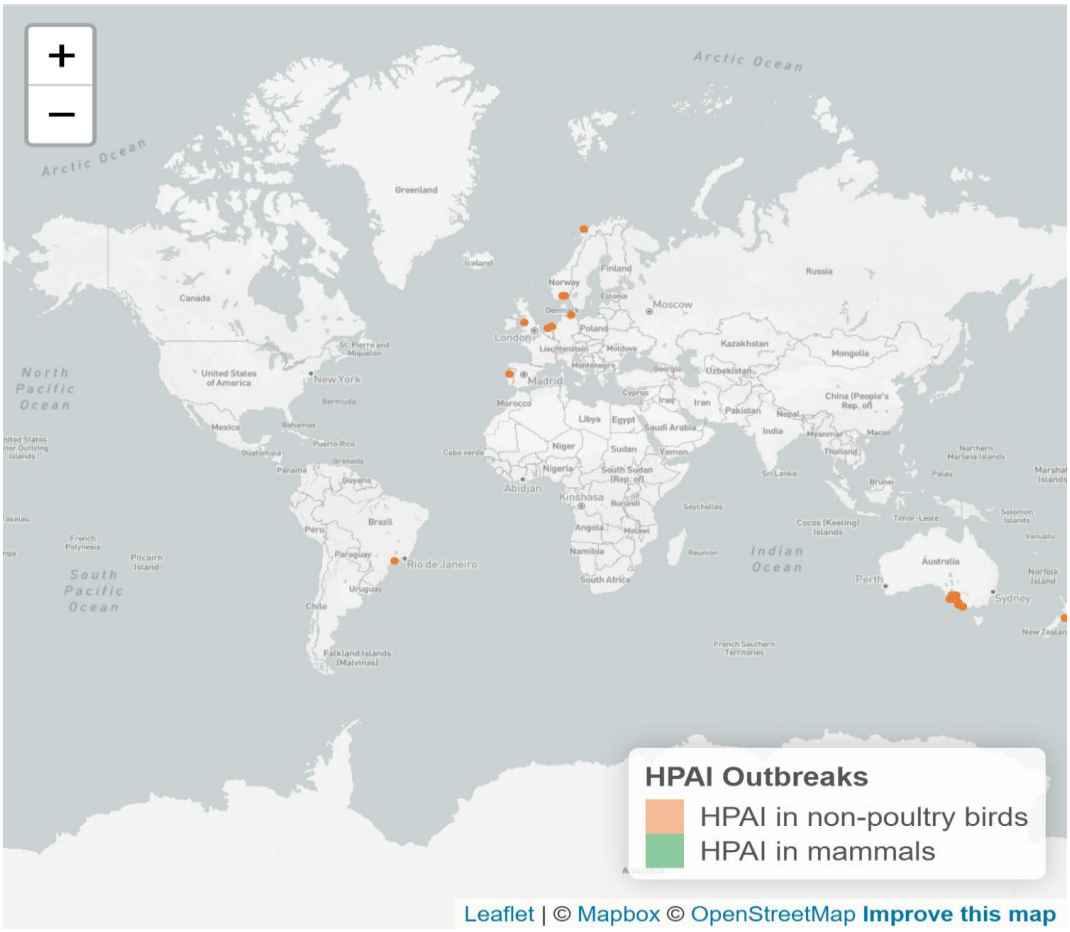


Figure 5. Distribution of HPAI new outbreaks in non-poultry and mammals reported through WAHIS.

[6] This list corresponds to countries and territories that have notified cases in wild birds, mammals or domestic birds other than poultry. This explains why their numbers are different from those presented on page 4 in the 'HPAI key figures for the current seasonal wave and the two previous waves' table, which does not cover domestic birds other than poultry.

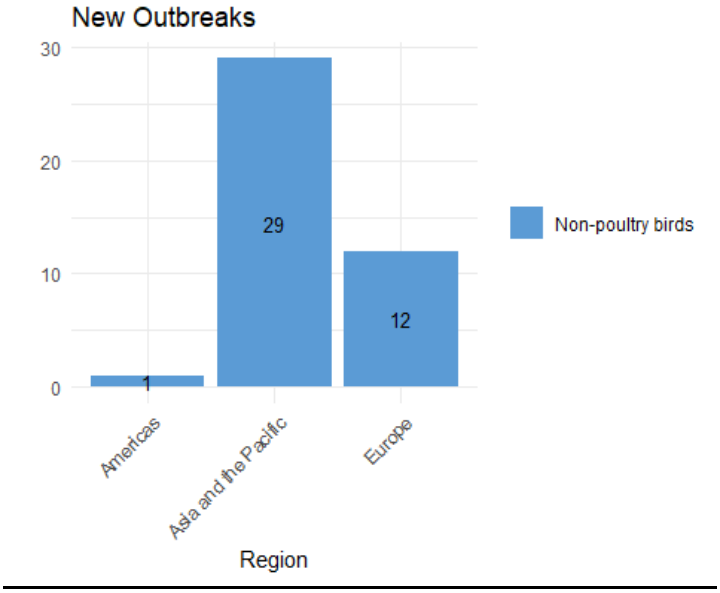


Figure 6. Number of new outbreaks in non-poultry reported through WAHIS by geographical region.

Self-declarations of freedom published during August 2026

In accordance with the provisions of the *Terrestrial Animal Health Code*, Members may wish to self-declare the freedom of their country, zone or compartment from HPAI. A Member wishing to publish its self-declaration for disease-freedom, should provide the relevant documented evidence of compliance with the provisions of the Code.

The WOAH Delegates of Poland, Albania and Czech Republic declared that the country complied with the requirements for recovery of freedom from infection with high pathogenicity avian influenza viruses in poultry, with self-declaration published on 5 August, 11 August, and 21 August, respectively, in accordance with Article 10.4.6. of the Terrestrial Code and consistent with the information provided in WAHIS.

Recent news

Preparing before the emergency: New Zealand's approach to HPAI
Australia notifies first case of High Pathogenicity Avian Influenza H5N1 in a wild bird
How WOAH's new and revised chapters ensure better control of avian influenza
HPAI Poultry Vaccination: Moving Beyond Trade Barriers
Updated joint FAO/WHO/WOAH public health assessment of recent high pathogenicity avian influenza A(H5) virus events in animals and people (based on data as of 1 March 2026)
Guidelines for Surveillance of High Pathogenicity Avian Influenza for Smallholder Poultry Systems in Resource-Limited Settings
Statement on the impact of HPAI on wildlife worldwide - WOAH - World Organisation for Animal Health
GF-TAD Webinar (December 2025): Update on the global situation of High Pathogenicity Avian Influenza (HPAI)
The State of the World's Animal Health
Statement on the impact of HPAI on wildlife worldwide
High Pathogenicity Avian Influenza (HPAI) in Cattle
Interview: Avian influenza prevention: could vaccination support egg security?
Case definition for HPAI in cattle
Updated joint FAO/WHO/WOAH public health assessment of recent influenza A(H5) virus events in animals and people
Global Strategy for the Prevention and Control of High Pathogenicity Avian Influenza (2024–2033)
Webinar of global strategy: Advancing Global Efforts for the Prevention and Control of High Pathogenicity Avian Influenza
Pathogenicity Avian Influenza - WOAH - World Organisation for Animal Health
Conclusions of the Meeting on Vaccination and Surveillance for HPAI in Poultry: Current Situation and Perspectives
WOAH HQ, Paris - France, October 22-23, 2024
GF-TADs Meeting: Detection of HPAI in Ruminants and Humans in the USA (cont.)

WOAH resources

Avian influenza portal
Self-declared Disease Status
WAHIS
Resoltuion adopted in WOAH General Session 2023: Strategic challenges in the global control of HPAI
Considerations for emergency vaccination of wild birds against high pathogenicity avian influenza in specific situations
Practical guide for authorised field responders to HPAI outbreaks in marine mammals
Webinar: Launch of Guidelines 'Mitigating Disease Transmission Risk at the Wildlife – Livestock Interface to Facilitate Safe Trade'

Awareness tools

Understanding avian influenza
Avian influenza: understanding new dynamics to better combat the disease
Avian influenza: why strong public policies are vital
Video: Avian influenza threatens wild birds across the globe

For any press inquiry on HPAI, e-mail us at media@woah.org.

OFFLU resources

OFFLU statement on the first detections of H5N1 HPAI in mainland Australia and New Zealand
Incursion of HPAI H5 into Australia and New Zealand with potential to impact wildlife populations and to spread further in oceania.
OFFLU statement on the use of the harmonised nomenclature system for A/H9 avian influenza viruses
OFFLU avian influenza matching (AIM) explainer video
OFFLU Summary Report from the WHO Influenza Vaccine Composition Meeting, February 2026
OFFLU Statement on the Development of a Global Consensus H5 Influenza Genotyping Framework
OFFLU Avian Influenza Vaccine Matching (AIM) for poultry vaccines: H5Nx executive summary October 2024
Updated OFFLU Statement on high pathogenicity avian influenza in dairy cows
Webinar: OFFLU Avian Influenza Matching (AIM) for Poultry Vaccines OFFLU diagnostic guidance: HPAI dairy cattle
Continued expansion of high pathogenicity avian influenza H5 in wildlife in South America and incursion into the Antarctic region

Other relevant resources

Cumulative number of confirmed human cases for avian influenza A(H5N1) reported to WHO
Human infection with avian influenza A(H5) viruses
WHO, Influenza at the human-animal interface, Summary and risk assessment from 23 January to 31 March 2026
HPAI Detections in Livestock